

4. Repositioning a Patient in Bed



Fig 1.

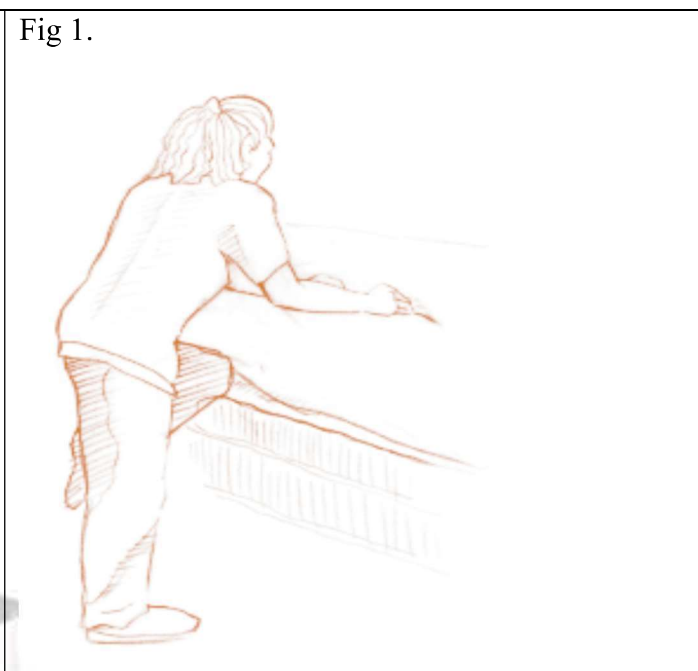


Fig 2.

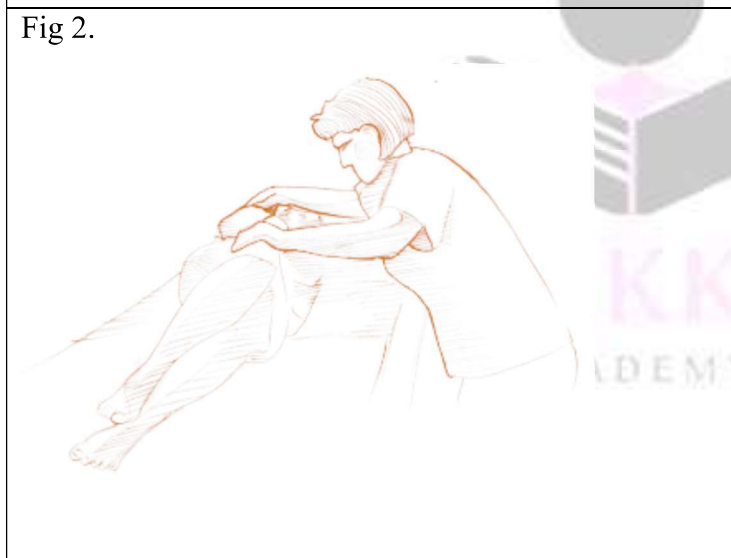
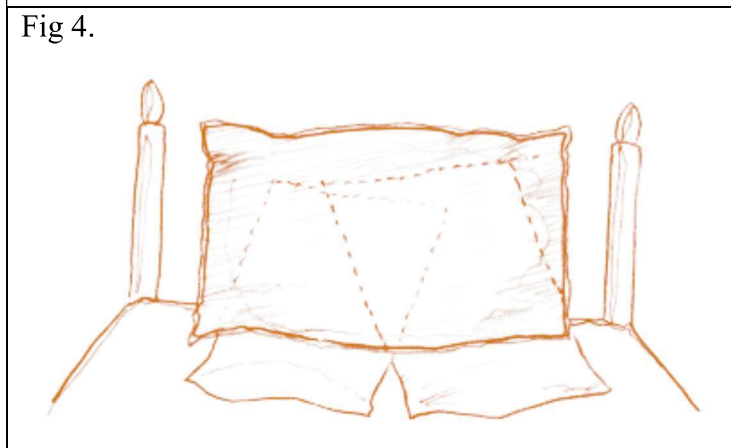


Fig 3.



Fig 4.



If someone is completely bedridden, is too weak to move, is paralyzed or is unconscious, changing the position in bed will become one of your most important tasks. Long periods without moving can lead to pressure sores, which is a serious problem. Also, changing position helps keep the person's lungs free of mucus and can help ease pain.

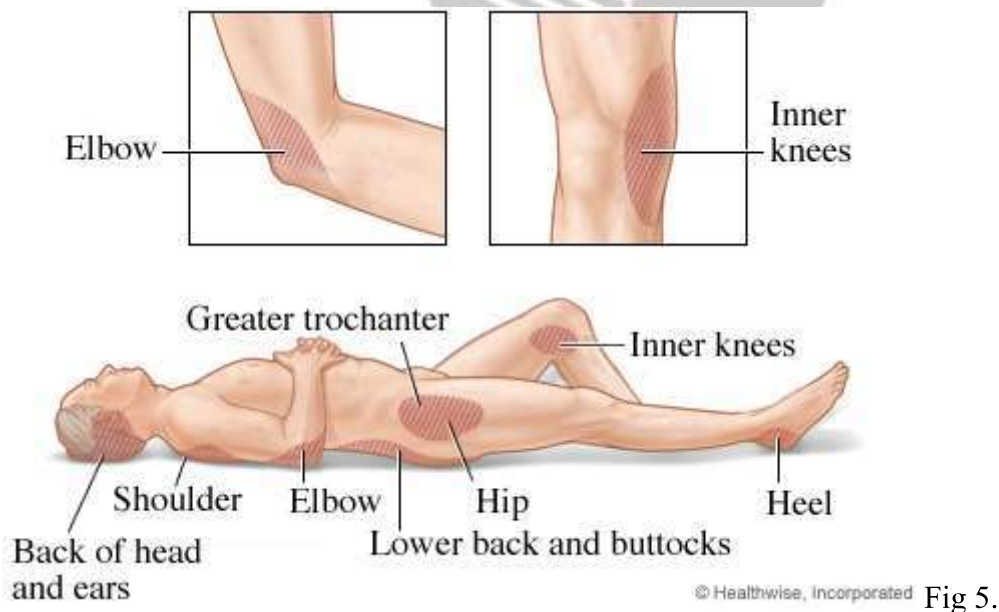
How you can offer care

Often when a person finds a comfortable position, it is a strong temptation to stay without moving. You may need to insist when helping your loved one to shift in bed.

- Lower the head of the bed if this is possible.
- Loosen the bed covers and remove extra pillows.
- Move the person toward you on one side of the bed so after the turn the person will be in the center of the bed. (See figure 1)
- Use a turning sheet to help roll the person over.
- If you do not have a turning sheet:
 - Stand on the opposite side of the bed from where the person is lying.
 - Place the person's far arm across the chest towards you. (See figure 2)
 - Bend the far leg at the knee and bring the bent leg towards you. As you do this, the far shoulder will naturally start to move towards you. Place your hand behind the person's shoulder and roll the body toward yourself. Do not pull the person's arm while doing this. (See figure 3)
 - Place the person's knees and ankles together in a flexed position.
- Place a flat pad or pillow under the knees and lower legs.
- Place a pillow lengthwise at the person's back and anchor it by pushing the edge under the person's back. Fold the outer side of the pillow under and tuck it in snugly against the person to give more support.
- Place a pillow lengthways under the person's thigh, bringing the leg forward so it does not rest on the lower leg. Position the leg comfortably.
- Place another pillow lengthways under the person's lower leg to prevent skin surfaces from rubbing together and to provide correct support. The pillow should extend well under the foot so the ankle and the foot do not drop and are kept level.

- Make sure the lower arm is in a comfortable position. The upper arm and hand may be more comfortable if they are placed on a pillow.
- When positioning someone on the back:
- Place two pillows lengthways at an angle. They should extend under the person's shoulders.
- Place one pillow across the top of the two lengthways pillows so it is under the head and reaching to the shoulders. (See figure 4).
- A bar above the bed called a monkey or trapeze bar is a device that can help with moving in bed if the person has good upper body strength. Ask your home care nurse or occupational therapist.

Attention to Pressure Areas



Skin breakdown or pressure sores can be a major source of discomfort for your loved one. Prevention of sores is a major part of physical care.

- Pressure sores usually happen over bony areas. (See figure 5).
- A back rub promotes blood supply to bony areas and can be relaxing as well.

- Encourage a person who can move unaided to change position in a bed or chair at least every two hours.
- Help a person who cannot move alone to turn every two hours during the day time and every four hours at night.
- Check the person's skin for any reddened areas. These may turn into pressure sores.
- Massage the back and pressure areas with lotion after each turn. Use soft pressure and move your hands in a circular motion.
- Do this several times, using plenty of lotion so that the movement is smooth.
- Protect reddened areas with pillows, sheepskin, elbow and heel protectors. Ask your home care nurse about other protective devices such as special mattresses.
- Use pillows to support the person on a side lying position. The pillows can be gradually pulled back, so that after two hours the person will be on the back.
- Keep the skin clean and dry.
- Keep bed sheets dry and free of wrinkles.

5. Making a Bed

For someone who is ill, the bed is often a place of refuge and comfort. If your loved one is confined to bed, the bedroom is the center of activity and should be kept tidy and restful.

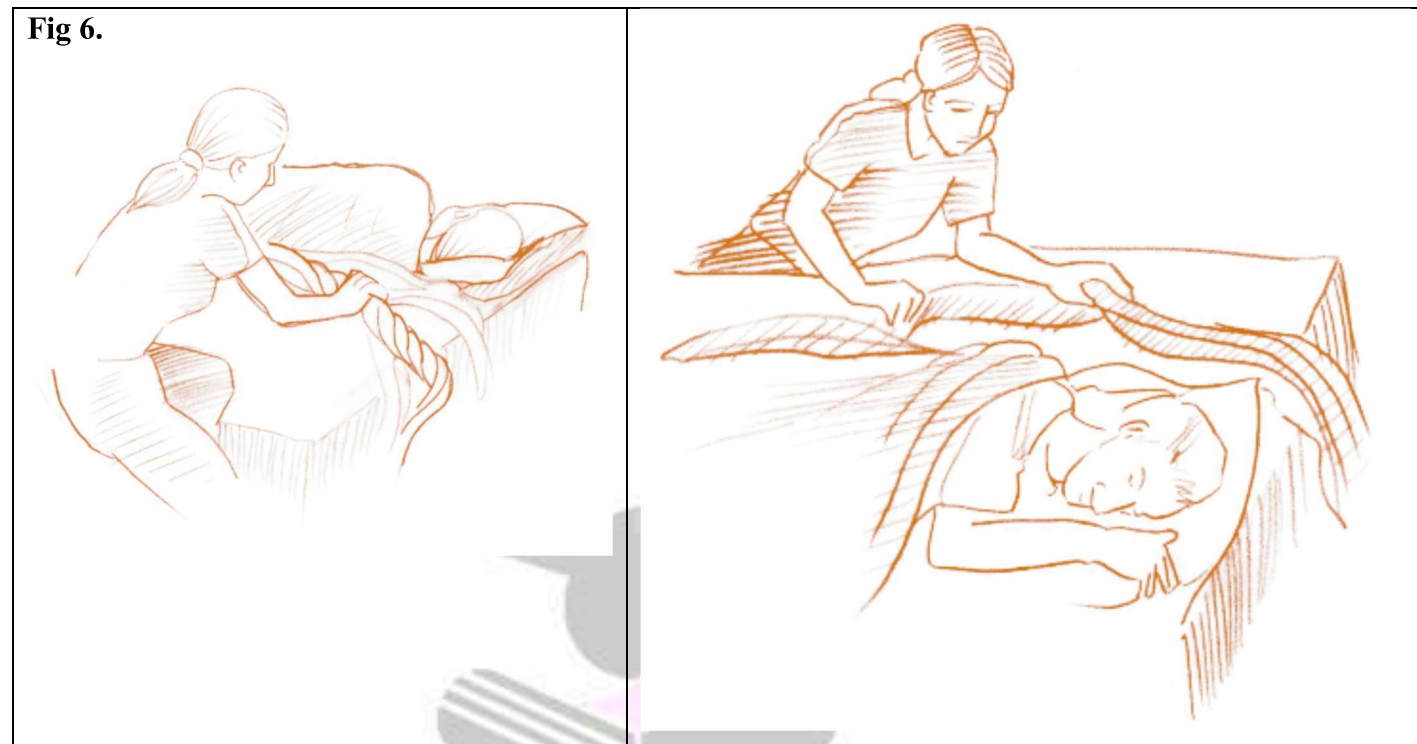
How you can offer comfort and care

It is important that the bed and surrounding area be kept clean to the patient from problems such as infections. Change the sheets at least once a week and whenever they are soiled.

- Start by asking the person if this is a good time for you to change the bed. Wait for another time if tiredness seems to be a problem.
- Give a pain medication if needed, then wait about 30 minutes before you start.
- Collect the clean bedding and take it to the bedside. Place it on a nearby chair.
- Have a laundry basket close by so you can put soiled bedding directly into the basket.
- Ask the person if it is possible to sit in a chair for a few moments while you change the bed.
- Raise the bed to your waist level if this is possible. Lower the head of the bed so the bed is level.

- Remove the soiled bedding and place it in the laundry basket. Check that the mattress is dry and clean.
- Put a piece of plastic sheeting across the middle section of the mattress to protect it from moisture, if the person has diarrhea or is incontinent. An opened garbage bag or incontinence pad (plastic side down) under the bottom sheet will do. Your pharmacist may be able to tell you about other products available in your province.
- Be sure the sheets are flat and free of wrinkles to help prevent skin breakdown.
- Consider a turning sheet over the bottom sheet. This can protect the bottom sheet from becoming soiled and may save you changing the entire bed next time. A flannel sheet or light blanket folded in half will do as a draw sheet.
- Place the clean top sheet and blankets on the bed. When tucking in the top layers leave a little slack at the foot of the bed so the covers do not push down on the person's feet. If you are using a foot cradle, put it in place before you add the top layers.
- Replace the pillowcases daily or when soiled, tucking loose ends inside.
- If using incontinence pads, place a fresh one on the bottom sheet where the person's bottom will lie.
- Lower a hospital bed to average bed height when you are finished.
- Help the person back to bed.
- Remove garbage such as used tissues.

Making a Bed with Someone in It



When a person cannot get out of bed it is easier to have two people to change it.

- Collect your bedding and laundry basket. If using a hospital bed, raise the bed to waist level and lower the head so the bed is level.
- Remove the top sheets, blankets and all pillows except the one that remains under the person's head. Cover the person with a sheet for warmth and privacy.
- Loosen the bottom sheets all around the bed.
- Help the person to turn onto one side while giving support at the waist and shoulders. Make sure the head is resting on a pillow and the limbs are supported.
- If there are two of you making the bed, one holds the person while the other rolls each layer of the bottom linens toward the center of the bed, close to the person's back. If the person has been incontinent take this chance to do a wash, then cover the soiled linens with a towel.

- If you are on your own, place a chair on the opposite side of the bed from you for the person to hang on to. If you have a hospital bed, raise the side rail and have the person hold on to that.
- Place the clean bottom sheet, rolled up lengthwise, against the rolled up dirty linens. Smooth out the flat half of the clean sheet and tuck it in. Repeat this process with each bottom layer of bedding you are using (mattress or foam, plastic sheeting, bottom sheet, draw sheet, turning sheet, incontinence pads). This will form a small hump. (Figure 6)
- Move the pillow to the other side of the bed and help the person turn over the rolls of bedding to the other side. Make sure to warn about the hump.
- If there are two of you, the other person now pulls through all the dirty linens and places them in the basket. Finish washing the person, then change the pyjamas. Pull through all layers of clean linen. Pull tightly to make the bottom layers straight and wrinkle free, then tuck in the sheets.
- If you are on your own, have another chair to hang on to, or raise the side rail, on the opposite side of the bed. Help the person roll over the hump. Go to the other side of the bed and do what a second person would have done.
- Help the person into a comfortable position. Replace the pillowcases and finish making the bed with a top sheet and blankets.
- Return the laundry basket and furniture to their regular places. Wash your hands.